

The party under his rule lost its biggest asset: the rural peasantry.



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PROTESTS AT SINGUR

profit to those whose land he was taking away," says Sarkar.

In another corner of the state, one woman was watching all this with unqualified glee. Mamata Banerjee was nowhere even two years back. But with Singur, she knew her time had come and it must be said of her latest political advisers and for her too, that she grabbed this opportunity with both hands. She sat on a dharna and fast for 25 days in December 2007 and her photographs did the daily rounds as if it was Gandhiji at Sabarmati. Nobody could be actually blamed for exaggeration here; the CPI(M) had painted itself to a corner worse than what the British did to aid Gandhi's fight for freedom.

Union minister of state for Rural Development, Shishir Adhikari, a Trinamool veteran, says, "His only contribution has been his white hair, his white clothes and black ego." Says Adhikari, "Mamata simply came and usurped the Leftist movement. It was handed over on a platter. The Left veterans were clean, they felt for the farmers and did lots for them which is why the LF has been able to stick to power for so long. Here, the rural peasantry was seeing their rights being usurped by the second and third generations of the same leaders. A huge vacuum had been created in the Left votebank. Mamata, with her clean image and fight against the Singur and Nandigram issues, just picked this votebank up like a lovely,

surprise gift," says Adhikari.

Industry which was Bhattacharya's touchstone and dream, actually proved to be his bane. His failure to keep back a corporate as huge as the Tatas, his mishandling of the Singur and Nandigram issues, his so-called favours to the Jindal group, and finally, the industrialists themselves, have been his worst enemies. The Vedic Village scandal, where one industrialist is believed to have made crores from land-grabbing with active help from CPI(M) leaders and worse, ministers who are now at war trying to prove their innocence. The Vedic Village scandal also dug the grave for Bhattacharya's pet project, the information technology (IT) sector, as the grabbed land had been earmarked for an IT park. Now that park plan stands abandoned.

Also, during the last six months, Bhattacharya's handling of the Maoist situation has left much to be desired. As his ministerial colleague, Kshiti Goswami, of the Front partner RSP, said, "I raised the question of the joint forces in Lalgarh and why we were spending millions on an operation which was yielding no tangible results. The only answer I got was that the chief minister would call a core committee meeting soon. That is yet to happen." For a chief minister who three years back had been dubbed the "best chief minister we have" by no less than Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, the fall has been sharp as much as his rise in 2000 had been meteoric. Goswami says: "He lacks in understanding the gap between objective reality and subjective preparation. In that way, he is a flawed administrator."

Indeed, the chief minister has been unable to attend two Politburo meetings in a row, refused an invitation by the prime minister to attend a chief ministers' meeting on the Ganges Erosion Plan and has not attended at least six chambers of industry meetings in the last one month, something unthinkable and worse, unheard of, for a chief minister. But he won't give up smoking though his chest is infected. It's quite like the ailing state he runs and his refusal to see reason. ■

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SHISHIR ADHIKARI,
Union Minister of State
for Rural Development

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